THE AFRICAN NETWORK | GLOBAL MOBILITY SERIES

THE SCHOLARSHIP BLUEPRINT

5 Strategic Steps to Securing Full PhD Funding in Russia & Europe

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I secured my PhD funding at HSE Moscow not by being the "best" candidate on paper, but by out-positioning the competition. This blueprint is the exact 5-step framework I used to move from KNUST to a fully-funded doctoral position.

STEP 1: THE RESEARCH FIT

FINDING YOUR SUPERVISOR

Don't apply to a university; apply to a **person**. Identify **3-5 supervisors** whose recent publications (last 3 years) align with your research interests.

- Use Google Scholar to track their citation trends
- Check if their lab is actively publishing
- Review their current PhD students' profiles

INSIDER SECRET: Look for **"Assistant Professors"** – they often have fresh funding and are *eager* to recruit doctoral students to build their research teams.

STEP 2: THE "INVISIBLE" CV

ATS-OPTIMIZED FORMATTING

Most high-tier applications are filtered by software before a human sees them.

Single-column layout	× No graphics or icons
LaTeX or plain Word format	× Avoid complex tables
Standard fonts (Times, Arial)	× No headers/footers
Quantifiable impact	× No columns for experience

PRO TIP: Write "Analyzed 10k+ data points using Python" instead of "Good at Python." Numbers get attention.

STEP 3: THE SOP NARRATIVE

THE "WHY RUSSIA/EUROPE" FRAMEWORK

Your Statement of Purpose must bridge your **past** → **present** → **future**.

1. **Opening Hook:** A compelling story about your academic journey
2. **Research Gap:** The specific problem you want to solve
3. **Why This University:** Mention professors, labs, resources
4. **Your Methodology:** What tools will you use (Python, R, Stata, etc.)
5. **Future Impact:** How will your research help Africa?

> **PRO TIP:** Address the "Urbanization-Growth Puzzle" (or your specific niche) and explain why *only* this university provides the unique tools for your success.

STEP 4: COLD EMAILING MASTERY

THE 3-PARAGRAPH FORMULA

Subject Line Format:

```
Prospective PhD Student:  [Your Research Interest] - [Your Name]
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Paragraph 1: **Who you are:** Your degree, university, and key achievement

Paragraph 2: **The Connection:** Mention a specific paper of theirs you read *(be detailed)*

Paragraph 3: **Call to Action:** Ask for a 10-minute Zoom call to discuss their current research

> **PRO TIP:** Follow up **once** after 7-10 days. Professors receive 100+ emails daily.

STEP 5: THE INTERVIEW "MOCK" PHASE

CULTURE & RESILIENCE CHECK

If you get the interview, you've already passed the technical bar. Now, they are checking for **resilience** and **culture fit**.

> **Practice explaining your methodology in 2 minutes or less.**

Common Questions to Prepare:

- "Why did you choose this specific research question?"
- "What will you do if your hypothesis fails?"

- "How do you handle academic criticism?"
- "Where do you see yourself in 5 years?"

PRO TIP: Record yourself answering these questions. Listen for clarity, confidence, and conciseness.

BONUS: THE TIMELINE

- **12-10 Months Out:** Research potential supervisors
- **9-8 Months Out:** Draft SOP and CV
- **7-6 Months Out:** Send cold emails
- **5-4 Months Out:** Submit applications
- **3-2 Months Out:** Interview preparation
- **1 Month Out:** Visa and relocation planning

Ready for Personalized Mentorship?

Book a 1-on-1 Strategy Session with Richard Asiamah

Limited spots available per month.

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